

On Your Own, Baby



The sense of déjà vu is gut-wrenching. On December 13, 2002, on the first anniversary of the attack on Parliament, India paused to pay homage. While honouring the bravehearts, prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee said, "We are determined to end cross-border terrorism and to protect the unity and integrity of India, whatever it takes." Members of Parliament paid homage to the martyrs. In Lahore, the government of Pakistan released Masood Azhar of Jaish-e-Mohammad and the former chief of the banned Lashkar-e-Toiba, Hafeez Mohammad Saeed, for "lack of evidence". Robert Blackwill, then US ambassador, reiterated "with full voice and strong heart that India and the US are together in the war against terrorism".

It seems like yesterday, nay tomorrow. Indeed, that eerie sense of promnesia is building up. In a few days, on the first anniversary of 26/11, India will say a requiem for the dead. Those alive will be grateful that there hasn't been another in 12 months. Perhaps because of *shamshan vairagya*, a period after bereavement when man becomes acutely aware of his mortality. India has been forced into a state of hyper alert and Pakistan is waging its own battle for immortality. The sense of security is rooted in the presence of P. Chidambaram as home minister. But this confidence is built around a personality. Coastal security is a myth. Helicopters with VIPs cannot be traced for nearly 24 hours. We have a 21st century agency for investigation but prevention is still dependent on 19th century lathi-charge governance. The porus system allows any terrorist, not just David Headley, to operate freely. The systemic rot in the states is an invitation for a bloody catastrophé. The next episode of mindlessness is somewhere around the corner. It will occur because nothing has changed.



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A year after, the sense of outrage may have been blunted by brutal reality but there is no denying India feels robbed of justice. Kasab is on trial but the perpetrators across the border will be mocking India come remembrance day. Saeed and his cohorts are out. In a tragic twist, those who should have been held answerable in Pakistan are asking India questions. So much for US pressure. Yes, the US has shared intelligence and mouthed barbed rhetoric, but it would be naïve to expect more. We may rush to open Kasab's cell doors for the FBI but that doesn't give us visiting rights for Headley. This, notwithstanding the "strategic relationship" with the US of A. Pakistan is clearly more "strategic". So let us stop running to the global cop. As the Americans say, "You are on your own, baby". Let us secure ourselves. The first step is to expect nothing.

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Parvathaneni

Upendra, 73, former Union minister for I&B and founder-member of the Telugu Desam Party.

UPENDRA



DIED: RSS leader and social worker **Dr Om Prakash Mengi**, 92. He joined the RSS in Lahore in the late 1940s and was the Sanghchalak of the RSS in J&K and Himachal Pradesh for 40 years.

INCLUDED: Kashi

Samaddar, 51, in the *Guinness Book of World Records*, for travelling to all 194 countries in the shortest time of six years, 10 months and seven days between July 2002 and May 2009.

DIED: Former Bollywood actor **Simple Kapadia**, who debuted with *Anurodh* in 1977. In 1994, she won a National Award for costume design for *Rudaali*.

